BALSAM FIR BRAISED MOOSE
WITH SUNCHOKE MASH

serves 4

This simple stew brings you a taste of the Great Lakes forests. Gamey moose meat gets braised in a dried mushroom broth with the aroma of fir. Ramps or baby leeks enhance the natural sweetness of the sunchoke mash served alongside. The vegetables in the stew get very soft, so I like to separate them out and serve them as an optional side dish. You can also make this dish with meat from elk or deer.

MOOSE

- 1 ounce mixed dried wild mushrooms
- 1½ cups boiling water
- 2 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 1½ pounds boneless moose stew meat, cut into 2-inch chunks (or substitute elk or deer meat)
- Sea salt
- 1 medium yellow onion, finely chopped
- 1 large carrot, scrubbed well and finely chopped
- 2 tablespoons maple syrup
- 1 ounce fresh or ½ ounce dried balsam fir boughs (see Conifers, page 22)

MASH

- 1¼ pounds sunchokes, each halved lengthwise
- 1 tablespoon sunflower oil
- 4 ramp bulbs, thinly sliced, or 1 baby leek, white and light-green parts only, thinly sliced crosswise
- Sea salt
- Wild onion greens or chives, thinly sliced, for garnish

Cook the moose: Preheat the oven to 300°F.

Place the mushrooms in a heatproof glass measuring cup. Pour the boiling water over them and let them rehydrate while you start the stew.

In a Dutch oven or ovenproof heavy pot, heat the oil over medium-high heat. Season the moose meat with salt. Working in batches, add the meat and cook for about 8 minutes, turning until browned all over. Transfer to a plate.

Reduce the heat to medium, add the onion and carrot, and season with salt. Cook for 3 to 5 minutes, stirring, until softened. Lift the mushrooms out of the water and transfer to the pot, stirring to incorporate. Return the meat to the pot. Pour in the mushroom soaking liquid, stopping before you reach any grit at the bottom of the measuring cup. Add the maple syrup, then add just enough water to come three-quarters of the way up the meat.

Bring the liquid to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low and add the balsam fir boughs. Cover and transfer to the oven. Cook for about 3 hours, or until the moose meat is meltingly tender.

Using a slotted spoon, transfer the meat to a plate. Strain the cooking liquid into a clean pot. Discard the balsam fir and reserve the vegetables, if desired. Bring the liquid to a boil and cook for about 20 minutes, until it is reduced to about 1 cup.

Return the meat to the sauce and keep warm. Reheat the vegetables in a separate saucepan, just until warm.

Meanwhile, make the mash: In a medium saucepan, combine the sunchokes with water to cover by 1 inch and bring to a boil over medium-high heat. Cook for 20 to 25 minutes, until tender.

Using a slotted spoon, transfer the sunchokes to a high-powered blender. Add 2 cups of the cooking liquid and let stand to cool.

Meanwhile, in a skillet, heat the oil over medium heat. Add the ramps and cook for about 3 minutes, or until softened but not browned. Scrape into the blender and puree until smooth. Season with salt.

Spoon the mash onto plates. Top with the braised moose and sauce and serve with the vegetables. Then garnish with green onions or chives.